What are the benefits of constructivist approaches for primary learners?

The theory of constructivism suggests that learners construct knowledge. This kind of approach promotes learning by doing, as learners construct new knowledge from their experience. Constructivist approaches describe how learning should occur, regardless of whether learners use their experiences to construct knowledge. This kind of learning is very much like a concept map, where learners construct knowledge by representing a real-world problem in a logical model. I think the constructivist learning model is popular today because of technology. We live in an information society, and so do today's learners. Today's learners operate in a digital and global environment dominated by digital devices. Look around; just about everyone has a cell phone or another digital device. I believe that technology is becoming part of people's lives and is a new way to communicate and learn. All the points mentioned in Appendix 1-A are constructivist approaches. I am just going to mention the first point that constructivist approaches engage students in meaningful and interactive learning experiences.

What limitations do other requirements contain in the project brief place on designing for constructivist learning?

A three-month timeline is so unrealistic. I say that three months is just about enough time to get the people talking. According to Appendix 1-A, the scope of the project is to design and develop high-quality online digital content (pg. 32). Given the requirements on page 21, can we develop an online course in three months? There is absolutely no way! Blackboard is a good example of what I am talking about. There are just too many moving parts—IT, development, domain experts, graphic designers, content writers, and so on. I think designing a constructivist learning model is more difficult because it must be tailored to learners' needs.

What compromises in constructivist design might need to be made to fulfill a project briefly?

Is there such a thing as compromising in learning? Could you just solve a part of the problem? Another hard question is which problem do we want to solve? If we are only going to solve part of the problem, we are not really achieving much. That is the same as saying that learners can choose any method for learning. What is wrong with this picture? This means that teachers need to prepare more than one lesson plan tailored to each student's needs. I think that there is more of a problem with this approach than solving it.

The prescriptive approach may seem like a good way to get the project moving, but it's really a bad idea. I don't believe that you can compromise in learning. It is the same as saying, "you can just do the minimum required for the assignment, and it's ok."

This is why case study 1 is about project management. In project management, it makes sense to have the master project's milestones drive each subproject team's milestones to keep schedules coordinated. To do this, we need to break the master project into phrases. Let's break this project into three phrases:

Phrase 1:
We will develop an interactive learning system that supports students in developing an understanding of contemporary society as a springboard for understanding self and others and for examining the contributions needed to bring about preferred futures (pg 22).

Phrase 2:
We will develop an interactive learning system that interconnects social, cultural, ecological, and economic systems.

Phrase 3:
We will develop an interactive learning system that supports students in developing values, understanding, skills, dispositions, and behaviors associated with civic decision-making and the principles of the democratic process, sustainable futures, and social justice.

This is project management. I've talked a lot about projects in my week 1 post. The project management role is coordinating the master project and subprojects. Now, for the first three months, phase 1 is more realistic and achievable.

Communicating Mathematics Using Heterogeneous Language and Reasoning from http://interactive-mathvision.com/PaisPortfolio/CKMPerspective/Constructivism(1998).html

A Learning Theory for the Digital Age from http//www.elearnspace.org/Articles/connectivism.htm

Experiential Learning ... on the Web from http://reviewing.co.uk/research/experiential.learning.htm

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Hi Jim,

Outstanding response to the week 1 deliverable! I very much enjoyed reading your real world perspective in acknowledging that 3 months is asking a miracle for the team to pull together a quality project. 3 months is not a lot of time to get a whole project together.

I also liked how you broke down the process into 3 distinct phases for the project from start to end. I think it is important when we are working on projects that we consider more than just the educational outcomes, and consider the "social, culture, ecological and economic system(s)" (Jim's post) for the project.

We need to consider the unique social, culture, ecological, and economic needs of the end users when developing not only the content, but also who the end users interact and use the software program. Thanks Jim for the reminder on these key points.

~Kim